

Scaling Before Stability

COLOPHON SAMPLE

A short, fictional case study demonstrating every feature of the Colophon toolkit

*Chapters, captioned tables, a landscape page,
an appendix, and citations — all in about ten pages*

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The company, people, and events described in this book are entirely fictional, invented solely to demonstrate the toolkit's chapter, table, figure, and citation features. Any resemblance to a real organization is coincidental.

Preface

This short book exists to demonstrate the Colophon toolkit's features end to end — not to teach business strategy. The case study is entirely fictional; the point is to show what a finished chapter, table, figure, appendix, and citation actually look like once rendered, so you can compare this file's Markdown source directly against the PDF it produces.

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Introduction

Meridian Mobility is a fictional ride-hailing company used throughout this sample to illustrate a common business pattern: expanding into a new, capital-intensive line of business before the original one is stable. The specifics are invented; the shape of the story is deliberately generic, since the point here is Colophon's typesetting, not the case study itself.

Chapter 1

Meridian Mobility: A Growth Story

Meridian Mobility launched in 2018 as a ride-hailing service in a handful of mid-sized cities. Its early growth was fast and, for the first three years, disciplined: expansion followed demand, not the other way around, and the company reached operating breakeven in its core market by year three — a milestone few competitors in the sector managed on a comparable timeline (A. B. Demo Author, 2020).

By 2021, Meridian’s leadership team faced a choice common to fast-growing platform companies: keep deepening the core ride-hailing business, or use its funding momentum to move into an adjacent, capital-intensive market. Table 1.1 summarizes the position each option started from.

Table 1.1: Meridian’s starting position in each business line, 2021.

Metric	Core ride-hailing	Proposed EV expansion
Market maturity	Established, profitable	Unproven, capital-intensive
Operational track record	3 years, stable	None
Leadership domain experience	Deep	Limited

The pattern this book uses Meridian to illustrate — a stable core business set aside in favor of a harder, unproven one — recurs often enough in platform-company case studies to be treated as a distinct failure mode, not a one-off (Christensen, 2019).

Chapter 2

The Expansion Decision

Meridian’s board approved the EV expansion in early 2022. Figure 2.1 shows the sequence that followed — generated with Graphviz and embedded as a normal figure, exactly as this toolkit recommends for diagrams (see the main README’s “Diagrams” section for why native Quarto diagram rendering is deliberately avoided here).

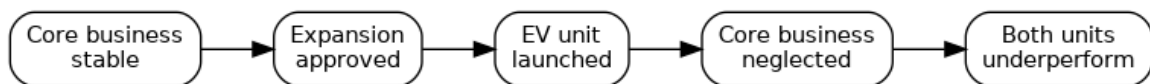


Figure 2.1: The sequence Meridian followed after approving its EV expansion.

Widening the comparison across all three of Meridian’s business lines — including the food-delivery pilot it had also launched — needs more horizontal room than a portrait page comfortably allows. This is exactly the case this toolkit’s landscape-page support exists for.

Table 2.1: Meridian’s three concurrent business lines, one year into the expansion.

Business line	Launched	Capital committed	Named owner	2022 status	2023 status
Core ride-hailing	2018	Self-funding	Head of Operations	Profitable	Declining share
EV manufacturing	2022	\$400M	Rotating, no single owner	Pre-launch	Delayed, over budget
Food delivery pilot	2021	\$40M	Head of Operations (dual role)	Stalled	Quietly discontinued

The Head of Operations holding both the core business and the food-delivery pilot — visible in Table 2.1 — is the kind of detail easy to miss in a narrative summary and hard to miss in a table: the same finding (C. D. Demo Author, 2021) shows up here as a structural fact, not an opinion.

Appendix A

Diversification Readiness Checklist

This checklist is a condensed, generic version of the questions Meridian’s board might have asked before approving the EV expansion. Note the automatic lettered numbering here — “Appendix A,” not “Chapter 4” — with zero manual bookkeeping required, thanks to \giEnableAppendix called at the end of the previous chapter.

Table A.1: A generic pre-diversification checklist, left blank for reuse.

Question	Answer	Evidence
Is the core business independently profitable, not just growing?		
Does the new line have a named owner distinct from the core business’s?		
Has leadership operated in this new market before, anywhere?		
Can the core business absorb 12 months of reduced leadership attention?		

References

Citations anywhere in this book — like A. B. Demo Author (2020) or (Christensen, 2019) — pull from `references.bib` and resolve automatically. Use `@key` for an inline citation or `[@key]` for a parenthetical one.

Christensen, C. M. (2019). *The innovator's dilemma: When new technologies cause great firms to fail* (Reprint). Harvard Business Review Press.

Demo Author, A. B. (2020). Scaling discipline in early-stage platform companies (illustrative citation for this sample). *Journal of Business Strategy (Sample Entry)*, 41(3), 12–21.

Demo Author, C. D. (2021). Founder-centric decision-making and organizational risk (illustrative citation for this sample). *Strategic Management Review (Sample Entry)*, 2(1), 45–60.

About This Sample

This short book is sample content shipped with the Colophon toolkit — not a real business case study. Every chapter, table, figure, and citation mechanism it demonstrates is documented in full in the main toolkit’s README and docs/BOOK-CREATION-GUIDE.md.



Figure A.1: The Colophon toolkit’s placeholder logo — swap this file for a real one when building your own book.

To use this sample as a starting point for your own book: copy this `sample/` folder out on its own, replace the fictional content in each chapter with your own, and update `brand.tex` and `title-page-content.tex` with your real title, colors, and fonts.

Thank You

Thanks for trying Colophon. If something in this sample didn't render the way this page describes, that's a real bug worth reporting — see `CONTRIBUTING.md` in the main toolkit.